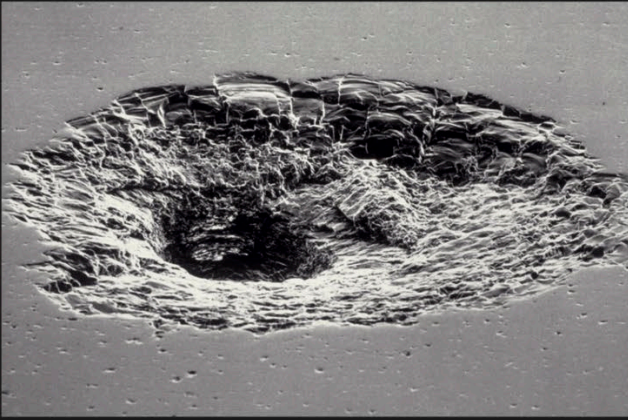




What are the dangers?

Items of junk are generally far apart in space, but problems arise when a fast-moving object, moving at speeds of up to 28,200 kph (17,500 mph), slams into a spacecraft or space station. This crater in a window surface on the space shuttle *Challenger* is typical of the damage caused.



Bits of space debris eventually fall into the Earth's atmosphere, where they either burn up or crash to the ground. This is the main propellant tank of the second stage of a *Delta 2* launch vehicle. It weighs approximately 250 kg (551 lb).



What can be done?

Before every launch, mission controllers make sure their spacecraft will not travel near any dangerous junk. Scientists are hoping to find a way to clear the Earth's orbit, but a solution is a long way off. These suggestions are being considered – lasers that can break objects up; space-rubbish ships; and technology that can tug rubbish lower so it burns up in the atmosphere.

Mission controllers keep a close watch on the path of their space launches.